

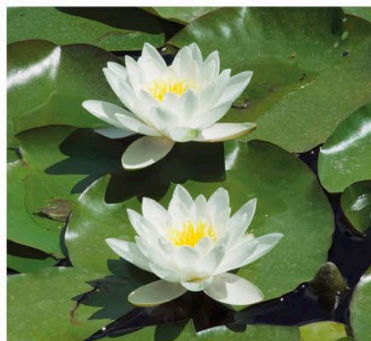
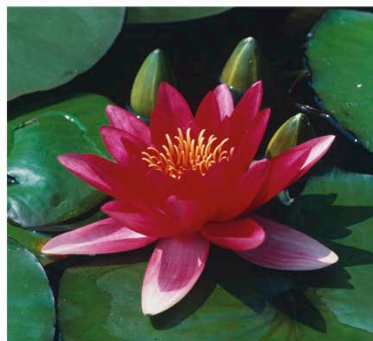
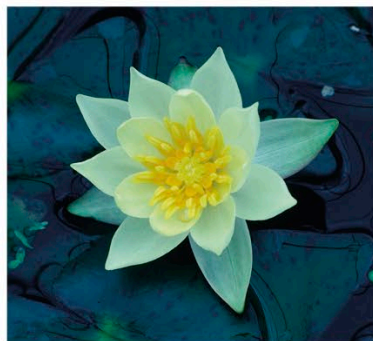
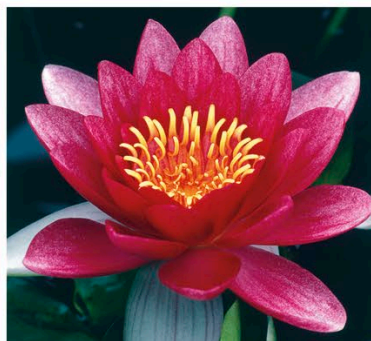


Plant focus: water lilies

The most flamboyant of all aquatic plants, water lilies are prized for their large, colorful summer flowers and decorative foliage.

WATER LILIES, KNOWN BOTANICALLY AS *NYMPHAEA*, make beautiful features in ponds and pools, where their dramatic blooms and rounded leaves create waves of color throughout the summer months. As well as providing ornamental value, water lilies play a useful role in aquatic ecosystems, their large leaves helping to regulate the water temperature and shield resident flora and fauna from pests and predators. When choosing a water lily, check the plant label for its final spread to ensure it will suit the size and depth of your pond. Also note that the tropical blue and purple forms are not hardy in most gardens and can be treated as an annual or overwintered in a warm, frost-free environment, such as a conservatory. Most water lilies grow at depths of between 18in (45cm) and 4ft (1.2m), although dwarf hybrids will thrive in shallow water less than 12in (30cm) deep. All forms prefer full sun and still water and do not grow well in streams or too close to fountains or waterfalls.

WATER LILY FORMS



Small water lilies Best suited to smaller ponds and features, this group prefers shallow water and a planting depth of 12–18in (30–45cm). Varieties include the pink-red *N. 'Ellisiana'* (top) and the pale yellow *N. 'Pygmaea Helvola'* (above), which both spread to 3ft (1m).

Medium water lilies This group is ideal if you have a deeper, medium-sized pond or plan to grow several plants in a larger pond. Requiring a planting depth of 24in–3ft (60cm–1m), *N. 'Gonnere'* (top) and *N. 'Escarboucle'* (above) both spread to 5ft (1.5m).

Large water lilies Only suitable for large ponds and lakes, these water lilies require a planting depth of 3–6ft (1–2m) and spread to more than 6ft (1.8m) across. *N. 'Attraction'* (top) has white or pink blooms. *N. alba* (above) produces large, pure white summer flowers.

USING WATER LILIES

Although water lilies will tolerate light shade, they flower best in full sun. New plants may take a year or two to reach full flowering size and should be split every 4–5 years to maintain vigor.



Miniature ponds Small-sized pygmy water lily varieties are ideal for growing in watertight patio containers, such as a half-barrel fitted with pond liner.



Wildlife ponds The leaves of water lilies help protect pond wildlife by cooling the water during summer. They also help to reduce algal growth, which keeps the water clear, healthy, and well oxygenated.

Formal ponds One or two lilies grown as specimens in a raised pool add an elegant note to a formal garden design.